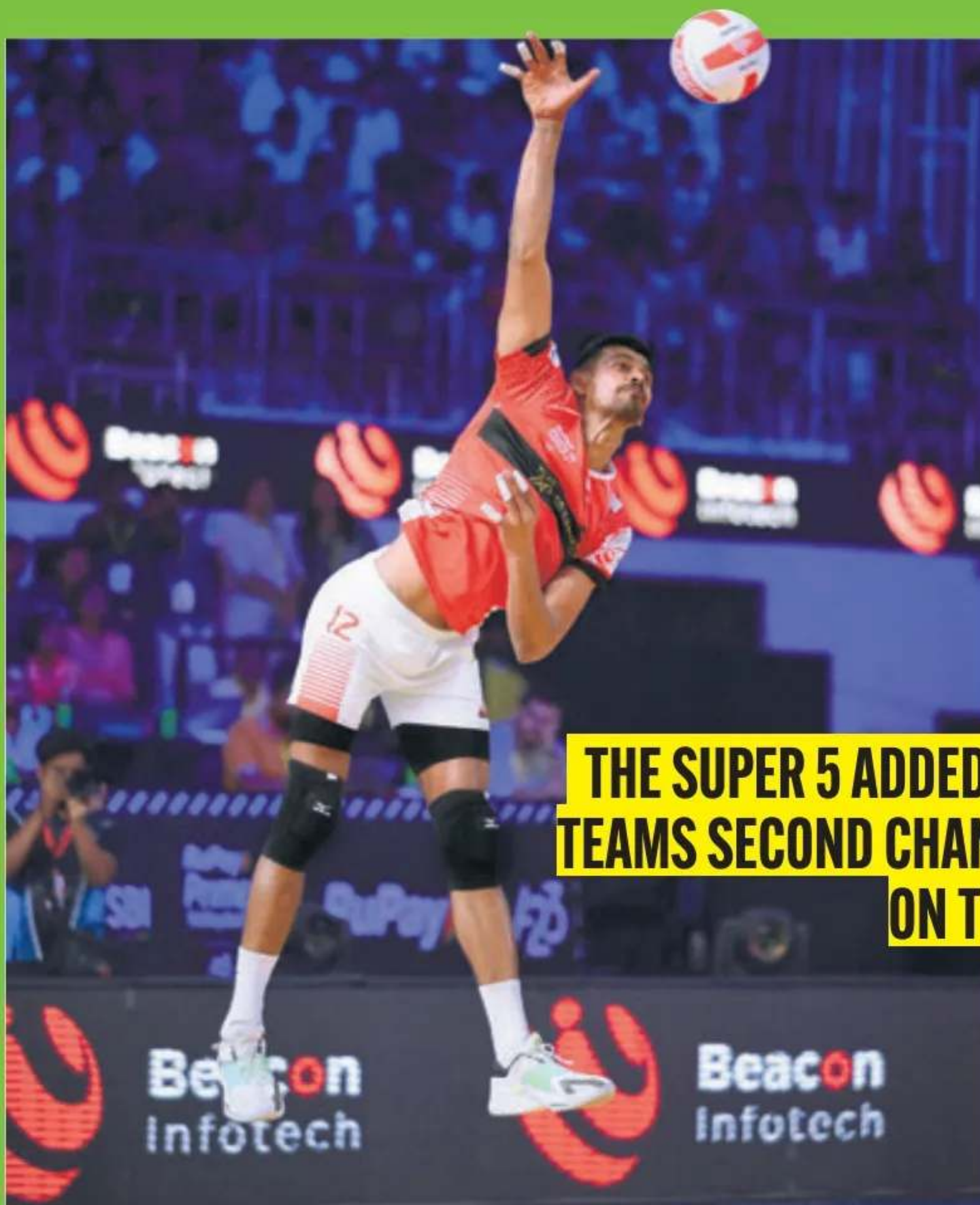




THE SUPER 5 ADDED EXCITEMENT, OFFERING TEAMS SECOND CHANCES AND KEEPING FANS ON THE EDGE OF THEIR SEATS

Leading from the front: Calicut Heroes' captain Jerome Vinith delivered a match-winning performance in the final, earning both Player of the Match and Most Valuable Player of the Season awards.

SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

increasing the talent pool for the national setup," Vinith tells *Sportstar*.

Super 5 heats up the competition

The addition of a ninth team necessitated a format change. Previously, a simple round-robin determined the semifinalists.

This season, a new Super 5 stage saw the top five teams battle it out. The winner secured a direct spot in the finals, while the others fought for the remaining slot.

This format intensified the competition, as evident in the final Super 5 standings.

All five teams had the same number of wins, separated only by set differences.

The increased number of matches also allowed players to build team chemistry.

The Super 5 added excitement, offering teams second chances and keeping fans on the edge of their seats.

International players and coaches brought fresh perspectives, noticeably improving the overall gameplay.

Luiz Felipe Perotto, the Heroes' Brazilian hitter, highlighted the difference in styles.

"Indian players are very aggressive; they tend to attack more and are very strong on serves and spikes.

On the other hand, European style leans more towards technical skills like receiving and blocking," he explains to *Sportstar*.

Challenges and looking ahead

Despite the season's success, challenges remain. Compared to international leagues, the PVL's shorter season limits player development. Additionally, the tight schedule increases injury risks, as seen towards the business end of the tournament.

Perotto also pointed out challenges for foreign players: "Top leagues in Europe run for 10 months, allowing time for development and team chemistry. In the PVL, it's a two-month sprint. We have to hit the ground running from day one."

However, Saqlain Tariq, captain of the Delhi Toofans, emphasised the importance of youth development. "The league allows youngsters to shine in a professional environment, something that was missing from Indian volleyball before," he tells *Sportstar*.

This season saw Indian talents like S. Santhosh, K. Anand, Chirag Yadav, Shikhar Singh, and Mukesh Kumar flourish alongside seasoned players like Vinith. Notably, seven of the top 10 scorers this season were Indians.

On the world stage

The Heroes' victory grants them direct entry into the Volleyball Club World Championship, representing India, the host nation. Bengaluru had hosted the 2023 edition, in which the Ahmedabad Defenders made history by becoming the first Indian team to compete in the tournament. Following suit, Chennai will stage this year's edition.

With PVL surpassing its 100-match milestone and crowning a new champion in its third season, the Indian volleyball scene is progressing towards a brighter future.